

Pterosaurs

The skies above the dinosaurs were alive with flying reptiles. These were the pterosaurs. They were not dinosaurs, but they were close relatives. One of the largest pterosaurs was *Quetzalcoatlus*. This colossal animal was easily the size of a fully grown giraffe—but with a wingspan that would have stretched across a tennis court.

Quetzalcoatlus

KWETS-ul-coe-AT-luss



- **When** 70–65 million years ago (Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains and woodlands
- **Size** 33–36 ft (10–11 m) wingspan

This pterosaur had a larger wingspan than a small plane, yet light bones meant that it only weighed around 550 lb (250 kg). During the day it soared over great distances, looking for small or baby dinosaurs to snap up in its giant, toothless jaws. It was one of the largest flying animals of all time.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Each wing formed from skin stretched between an extra-long finger and the leg.
- Some pterosaurs had head crests.
- Large eyes
- Long, narrow jaws
- Hollow bones
- Pterosaurs flapped their wings

When

Pterosaurs first appeared in the late Triassic, 215 million years ago, and survived until the end of the Cretaceous Period, 65 million years ago.